

Making sense of gender and organizational change

A feminist review of selected articles

Albert J. Mills, Kathy Sanderson and Jean Helms Mills 

In this chapter we use the lens of Critical Sensemaking (CSM) to review the literature on organizational change and gender. Specifically we focus on two interrelated themes: (i) organizational change programs and the gendering of organization—exploring the impact of such programs of gendered practices; and (ii) gendered organization and change—exploring the implications of feminist theory for organizational change practices. We conclude with a synthesis of insights from the literature review and suggested strategies for changing gender and gendering change.

The Critical Sensemaking lens

Critical Sensemaking, or CSM, originates from the work of Weick (1995) who viewed the process of organizing through the lens of seven inter-related socio-psychological properties. The seven properties constitute what Weick (1995) sees as a sensemaking process through which people construct a sense of organization. The properties consist of the ongoing *identity* construction of the individual as he or she makes sense of events; the socio-psychological influences of relevant *social* groups on the sense of a situation; contextual *cues* that shape the direction of a given sense; the psychological need to ensure the *on-going* sense of a situation; the *retrospective* nature of sensemaking as people make sense of what has occurred; and the *plausibility* of a given sense that facilitates its *enactment*.

Weick's (1979, 1985, 1995, 2001) socio-psychological approach to organization, we contend, is important in shifting attention to agency and social construction and away from overly rationalized and structural accounts (Helms Mills, 2010; Helms Mills and Mills, 2009; Mills, 2008a). Nonetheless, as has been argued elsewhere (Helms Mills, 2003; Mills and Helms Mills, 2004; Thurlow, 2010), Weick's sensemaking lens fails to adequately take into account the gendered aspects of sensemaking processes. Nor does it adequately deal with power and structure as influences on and through the sensemaking process. It is also epistemologically problematic in its assumption of, what Johnson and Duberley (2000: 3) refer to as a "presupposed knowledge of the conditions in which knowledge takes place." In dealing with these questions we take a "consciously reflexive" (Johnson and Duberley, 2000: 4) approach that identifies the impossibility

of “coming to a foundational set of epistemological standards ... while [maintaining] consistency with regard to the epistemological assumptions” (Johnson and Duberley, 2000: 177) we adopt.

To deal with contexts of power, structure, and knowledge we draw on the work of Mills (1988, 2008b), Unger (1987), and Foucault (1979) to deal respectively with the rules, formative contexts and discursive fields in which sensemaking takes place. We call this approach Critical Sensemaking (Helms Mills and Mills, 2009; Mills and Helms Mills, 2004; Thurlow, 2010).

Organizational change

In terms of organizational change the CSM lens focuses on the socio-psychological processes and contexts associated with specific change initiatives. Thus, organizational change is not viewed as a concrete outcome of an identified (Kotter, 1996), or even unconscious (Mintzberg, 1978), set of problems but rather as an *enacted* sense of change. In the process the CSM approach is interested not only in the processes leading up to an enacted sense of change but also such things as the power differentials involved and the identity outcomes for those affected by the enactment. In particular, we are interested in the gendered outcomes of the enactment of organizational change.

Gender, Critical Sensemaking, and change

Through a focus on the socio-psychological properties of organizational change CMS draws attention to the role of meaning and the implications for identity and organizational stability. This stands in sharp contrast to mainstream theories of organizational change, which tend to treat change as artifactual, i.e., *something* that is altered through attitudinal (Coch and French, 1948), job (Hackman and Oldham, 1980), structure (Schash and Bell, 1972), culture (Schein, 1985), process (Hammer and Champy, 1993), structure (Kotter, 1980), and/or measurement (Kaplan and Norton, 1992) changes. The artifactual approach tends to focus on change as an entity (more or less separate or separable from human intent) that can be manipulated through alterations in any number of variables, or other *things*, that are viewed as influencing, rather than the outcomes of, human behavior. “People” in the organizational change literature are often viewed through an essentialist lens, which pays little or no attention to identity (seeing it as a more or less fixed entity). If anything the focus is on altered attitudes and/or behavior with little regard to the potential changes to the way people view their selves and others. Instead, people tend to be viewed as a variable (e.g., the “human factor”—see, for example, Danny C. K. Ho, 1999; 1944) that, when subject to organizational change, can benefit in terms of participation in decision-making, higher income, more satisfying work, better customer relations, increased efficiencies, profitability, and enhanced status—particularly for senior managers and employers (Helms Mills et al., 2008); rarely is equity seen as part of the potential outcomes or subject of organizational change (Helms Mills, 2005).

A focus on the socio-psychological processes of organizational change, on the other hand, serves to problematize organizational change by revealing its socially constructed character, and raises questions about its influence on identity, including gender identity. A focus on the sensemaking nature of organizational change also points to its relatively unstable character as meanings change overtime, especially in the face of “shocks” to the way people understand organizational reality (Weick, 1995). As such, as we have argued elsewhere (Mills and Helms Mills, 2004; Mills and Helms Mills, 2010), instability offers the potential for challenges to the gender order.

Organizational change programs and gendered outcomes

The idea of programmatic change took hold in the last quarter of the twentieth century as culture change became a popular intervention technique (Davies, 1984; Deal and Kennedy, 1982; Peters and Waterman, 1982).

The development of an organizational culture focus within management and organization studies was accompanied by much optimism from postpositivist researchers (Smircich, 1983; Weick, 1985), who heralded the move away from a rationality and systems thinking towards issues of symbolism, identity and emotionality. Within this framework feminists were optimistic that, as a heuristic, organizational culture would open an intellectual space for consideration of gender and organization (Gherardi, 1995; Mills, 1988). Feminists had long argued that gender was an outcome of culture and cultural relationships (Ryan, 1979) and in a field of study that had long neglected gender (Hearn and Parkin, 1983) a focus on organizational culture promised to open debate about the role of masculinities (Collinson and Hearn, 1994) and femininities (Ferguson, 1984) at work. Yet it was a promise that basically failed to materialize as organizational managers and educators increasingly focused on adapting symbols, values and beliefs to create more efficient organizations through creating such things as a sense of identity and belonging among employees and by assisting management to understand how to shape and direct important aspects of an organization's culture (Schein, 1992). In the process the notion of organizational culture was objectified as practitioners and educators increasingly came to think of it as a thing to be manipulated rather than a heuristic for helping people to make sense of their organizational experiences and relationships (Smircich, 1983).

From the late 1980s onwards a series of different organizational change programs became variously popular over time, and include Total Quality Management (TQM), Business Process Re-engineering (BPR, reengineering or re-engineering), Six Sigma, the Balanced Scorecard and Appreciative Inquiry—see Abrahamson (1996), Kieser (1997) and Jackson (2001) for accounts of the various developments.

Gender and the enactment of organizational change

Despite the widespread changes that have occurred in the name of organizational change and a burgeoning literature there has been very little study of the outcomes for the people involved in terms of identity—especially gendered identities—discriminatory practices, and issues of self esteem, etc.

A review of the literature of organizational change reveals that the vast majority of articles fails to take gender into account. For example, a title search for “organizational change” on ABI/INFORM (ProQuest) results in a total of 964 hits within scholarly journals (as of October 15, 2009). When gender is added as a search component within the abstract, that figure is reduced to 13 (or 1.34 percent). When gender is a title search with organizational change, there are only 5 articles found (0.5 percent). A search of Business Source Complete show similar results: change management as a title search provided 501 articles (as of March 29, 2010), but only 3 (0.6%) when gender was added to the abstract.

If we look at gender and popular organizational change programs we find a similar picture. Using the search component “gender” and the name of a selected change program our ABI/INFORM (ProQuest) searches yielded the following results for six popular change programs:

Table 34.1 Percentages of gender issues in change management programs

Change Program	Total abstract references*	Incl. references to gender	Percentage gender references
Balanced Scorecard	1372	0	0
Six Sigma	2169	0	0
Appreciative Inquiry	171	1	0.6
Re-engineering	6565	3	0.05
TQM	8163	6	0.07
Culture change	9186	106	1.15
TOTAL	27,626	126	0.45

Note: * We used an “abstract” only search to ensure that gender and the selected change programs were central foci in a given article

We also undertook an EndNote search on the Library of Congress website for books that combined a focus on gender and one or other change program. That search yielded 0 books focussed on gender and Six Sigma, Appreciative Inquiry, Re-engineering, or TQM; 1 book on gender and the Balanced Scorecard, and 25 books on Corporate or Organizational/Organisational culture and gender. These figures suggest an overall field of inquiry that has little or no concern with gender issues. The sheer number and focus of most of the articles and books presents an *on-going sense* of organizational change.

In her study of the sensemaking practices of a major Canadian corporation undergoing change Helms Mills (2003) argued that senior managers accepted the need to change as if it was an imperative—a more or less requirement with its roots in such things as competition, technological changes, globalization, and new management techniques. In making decisions, not on whether but what type of change process to enact, Helms Mills (2003) found that senior managers were influenced by widespread practices across the industry (social sensemaking), and business in general (on-going sensemaking), and a perceived sense that the ideal-typical manager was someone who adapted to change (identity). Abundant sensemaking cues—local, national and international companies who had adopted culture change—made it increasingly easy to see the adoption of a similar program as plausible. In the process of adopting their own culture change program, argues Helms Mills (2003), the company simultaneously enacted a sense of culture change (as an important and much needed process) and made retrospective sense of the factors (such as a need for improved morale through greater sense of purpose) supposedly leading up to adoption of a culture change program—something that needs urgent and vital attention in regards to organizational survival and prosperity in a global context. It is an impact that is reinforced in practice—as numerous organizations across North America and (other industrialized countries) adopt one or other of these change programs (Helms Mills, 2003), but also in theory—as various academics and consultants serve—as part of the *social sensemaking* environment—to construct ways to encourage the adoption of one or other change program or organizational change in general. As such, in critical sensemaking terms, this large body of literature and practices serve to construct a powerful discourse that *enacts* a dominant view of organizational change.

Gender and the organizational change literature

Feminist studies of work and organization have long dealt with the issue of change, specifically that change designed to address gender discrimination, yet few have engaged with the

organizational change literature per se. There are many reasons for this, including the overwhelming managerialist focus of much of the work, its often atheoretical and ahistorical slant and its positivist world view (Burrell and Morgan, 1979; Hearn and Parkin, 1983). Nonetheless, these are both reasons for adopting alternative paradigms or traditions (Burrell and Morgan, 1979; Prasad, 2005) and understanding the processes of and implications for knowledge production in the selected field of organizational change. To that end, in the rest of this chapter we want to directly engage with the organizational change literature to understand its discursive effects (Foucault, 1980).

A review of the various articles on gender and organizational change programs (see Table 34.1) reveals some of the potential problems associated with ignoring gender. We begin with those change programs that have little or nothing to say about gender – Six Sigma and the Balanced Scorecard.

Six Sigma and the Balanced Scorecard

Six Sigma has been described as “a set of practices that combines statistical techniques and management training to improve organizational processes—of cost minimization, schedule adherence, high product quality and customer satisfaction—specifically through the elimination of defects” (Helms Mills et al., 2008, p.110). Similarly, the Balanced Scorecard “is a method for developing strategic objectives through the measurement of key financial, structural and process factors linked to organizational performance critical to its success” (Helms Mills et al., 2008, p. 103).

On the surface, these approaches, with their focus on scientific method and measurement, appear gender-neutral. Indeed, one feminist researcher suggests that the Balanced Scorecard can be used as “a management tool to achieve gender mainstreaming in organizational culture” (Floeter-van Wijk, 2007). However, critics have argued that Six Sigma and the Balanced Scorecard can have a powerful influence on the mind-set of employees and managers by narrowing the focus to error reduction and measurement at the expense of other issues and concerns (such as innovation), “shifting attention from intangible assets to those that can be measured ... [and] ignoring many of the non-measurable factors that constitute the culture of an organization, such as values, beliefs, symbols, systems of communication, and interrelationships that may contribute to the strength of the organization,” encouraging rigid behaviour and leaving little room for “cross perspectives” (cited in Helms Mills et al., 2008, p. 114). A feminist concern here would be the extent to which a focus on such issues as employment equity could get lost in the concern for narrowly focussed, measurable interests. Discursively, while scientific approaches and measurement are not male characteristics per se, the privileging of rational models of change can—if not checked and reflected on—serve to reinforce masculine associations with the dominant thought processes that underlie the philosophies of Balanced Scorecard and Six Sigma. In the latter case, this concern is underscored by the widespread use of martial arts metaphors and symbols that are applied to a hierarchical system of training, processes, teams and leadership. Thus, for example, it has been called a “statistical thinking paradigm” that is enacted through *Executive Leaders* who are the visionaries of the program; *Champions*, drawn from management, who oversee the process; *Master Black Belts*, who play an integration role; *Black Belts* who execute the program; and *Green Belts*, specially trained employees, who work under the Black Belts. It is not a stretch of the imagination to speculate how this highly focussed way of thinking—with its focus on measurement and performance outcomes—can privilege some identities (e.g., the mathematician, the black belt) and marginalize others (e.g., those viewed as innumerate or not Black Belt material). It is also not too much of a stretch to imagine how such

identities can become more or less associated with either masculinities (privileged) or femininities (marginalized).

Appreciative Inquiry

Despite the fact that Appreciative Inquiry (AI) has been around since the 1980s and was adopted at one time by the United Nations it remains one of the lesser known and discussed approaches to change. This may be due to its focus away from objectivist models of measurement and problem solving towards a focus on “finding the best in people and discovering what works best in an organization and then ... building on and celebrating these successes” (Helms Mills et al., 2008, p. 83). It involves a “4-D process” of discovering the underlying strengths of individuals and the organization; dreaming or envisioning what might be; designing for what could be; and destiny, “sustaining what has been achieved” (Helms Mills et al., 2008, p. 84). As such, it carries the potential to open discursive spaces for discussions of more equitable organizations. Yet, to date, little has been done to discuss and develop AI as a method for addressing discriminatory practices. Sekerka et al. (2006) is the only published study to show interest in gender but only as a “moderating effect” on the way people understand and respond to a diagnostic tool used as part of an AI study. Interestingly, however, they conclude that AI “seemed particularly effective at encouraging men to engage with the task and to broaden their thinking ... ” (p. 472). They speculate that this may be because the AI “task contrasts with their typical mode of communication [and] may have garnered deeper thinking and engagement that will lead to better outcomes in subsequent phases of the change process.” In other words, the researchers may be describing some form of “shock” (Weick, 1995) to the ongoing sense that encouraged new senses to be constructed. On the other hand, women in the study are described as being less creative as an outcome of the AI task “perhaps because of its consistency with their typical mode of conversing” (p. 472). Apart from the obvious problem of essentializing the assumed characteristics of women and men the study also fails to develop further study into the gendered insights unearthed. Arguably, with its focus on the “best” in people AI could be adapted to a more gender reflexive approach if such things as context and definitions of best are taken into account.

Re-engineering

According to Hammer and Champy (1993, quoted in Helms Mills, et al., 2008, p. 97), re-engineering is “the fundamental rethinking and radical redesign of business processes to achieve dramatic improvements in critical contemporary measures of performance, such as cost, quality, service and speed.” Radical critics have argued that re-engineering is a new form of deskilling (Braverman, 1974), with work redesigned by teams according to identified organizational processes and workflows (see Helms-Mills et al., 2008). Critics also point to the far reaching job losses that usually accompany the introduction of re-engineering, and the fact that there is little evidence to document the successful implementation of re-engineering (Helms Mills, 2003). Even Hammer and Champy (1993) contend that three-quarters of all attempts fail—but they blame it in the ineptitude of the managers involved.

Analyses of the gendered aspects of re-engineering are few and far between. ABI/INFORM yielded only one article and two doctoral thesis on the subject, none of which was centrally focussed on gender. The one article (Dowlathshahi, 1994) on the subject only considered gender tangentially to re-engineering, being more concerned with the influence of re-engineering on higher education outcomes that include, among other things, gender disparities in graduate starting salaries. Of the two theses, one relegates gender to future research into its impact on

perceptions of re-engineering leadership (Morreale, 2002), while the other takes up that very issue, finding little difference between males and females in their perceptions of management competencies in the application of re-engineering (Altman, 2006). Nonetheless, it can be argued that, like Balanced Scorecard and Six Sigma approaches, re-engineering's over-focus on process efficiencies can serve to narrow concern away from the human side of enterprise, including gender discrimination. As with Six Sigma, the language use and symbolism involved in re-engineering evokes masculine-associated metaphors of dominance, destruction, and fighting (e.g., "don't automate, obliterate" and "revolution"—see Hammer, 1990, 1995). In Helms Mills' (2003) study of Nova Scotia Power the senior managers in charge of re-engineering were called, and embraced, the names "gunslinger" and "undertakers" to describe their radical new role in the organization.

Total Quality Management (TQM)

TQM has been described as "an organization-wide method of managing people and processes to ensure the continuous delivery of quality products and services" (Helms Mills et al., 2008, p. 92). Again, despite its widespread use and potential implications for the identity work of organizational members there is little research on the outcomes for gendered practices. Critics have argued that some of the human problems of TQM include increased stress for employees who are required to take on new administrative duties and responsibilities concerned with "job enrichment" and "involvement" (Helms Mills et al., 2008).

Studies of gender and TQM are limited (in number and scope) and mixed in their results. Lian (2001, p. iii) suggests that males are more likely than females to contribute "positively to TQM implementation," while Aksu (2003) and Ehigie and his colleagues (Ehigie and Akpan, 2005; Ehigie and McAndrew, 2005), respectively, suggest that gender does not seem to influence the "readiness" to adapt to or the "practice of" TQM: Ehigie and Akpan (2005) draw on their results to argue against discriminatory hiring where it may be assumed that women are less capable of working within a TQM system of work. Cockerill-Walker's (1997) study of participants' experience of TQM found "a few gender differences" (p. 113) in regard to the way males and females conceptualized the relationship between the "tools" needed to do the work (females took a more system-wide approach), toleration of the time taken to complete tasks (males were less tolerant), and the requirements of team interactions (males were initially less comfortable).

Two feminist studies on TQM provide contrasting views on the potential value of the approach and the outcomes for women and men. The first—by Graham and Hotchkiss (2009)—applies a "conceptual application of theories of total quality management (TQM) to the topic of gender-related employment" (p. 578). They argue that the "application of TQM theory to the topic of gender-related employment disparities is a novel approach that may motivate new public policies;" as such "further conceptual work on the application of TQM to gender disparities in employment is recommended" (ibid.). Armstrong, Armstrong, Choiniere et al. (1997), on the other hand, come up with radically different recommendations from their empirical study of TQM in a hospital system in Canada. Basically, Armstrong et al. (1997) argue that the introduction of TQM in the not-for-profit health care system can have deleterious effects on working conditions and patient care. They contend that TQM shifts attention from the concern with people to more abstract thinking through an over-focus on measurement; tends to be introduced from above (with attendant tendencies to reproduce existing dominant viewpoints) and short-circuits unions; shifts the focus from patient-care to customer satisfaction, with all the attendant shifts in conceptualizations; introduces standardization and competitiveness to areas where there is a need for localized initiatives and cooperation; encourages a deskilling

of labor as process structures replace employee task execution and initiative. Finally, the seemingly innocuous use of “team” work (that is central to TQM) drastically reconceptualized existing notions of teams (as a cooperative set of interrelationships) to take on more of an inherently masculinist one (as a competitive group designed to outperform other groups). Perhaps what we are seeing here are attempts to enact a sense of organization using cues (e.g., “team”) that are rooted in other, contradictory social senses and thus leading to conflict and confusion in the system. With one of the results being a discursive shift of certain feminine or more gender balanced practices towards more masculinist understandings of organizational practice.

Organizational culture, change and feminist debate

By far the largest area of debate around issues of gender and organizational change can be found in the literature on organizational culture, and it is to this debate we now turn for insights.

It is perhaps fitting as well as understandable that most of the insights generated on gender and change have come from a focus on organizational culture. Feminists have long identified this focus as having the potential to open space for discussion, long neglected within management and organization studies (Hearn and Parkin, 1983; Wilson, 2003), around issues of the gendered nature of organization. It has generated not only a substantial number of articles but numerous books and edited collection on organizational culture and gender. Nonetheless, in terms of space and sheer scope we will restrict our study to the selected articles.

Analytical framework

To begin, we view the literature as located in two broad foci—social constructionist and essentialist. The latter can be found in those studies that categorize rather than problematize (the cultural differences between) “men” and “women.” The former, while acknowledging embodied differences, focuses on the factors that serve to construct cultural differences and understandings of maleness and femaleness. As is evident from the beginning of this chapter, we take this social constructionist approach but apply it across the literature to gain insights into the various findings.

Essentialist insights

The great bulk of the essentialist studies cast gender as a variable—sometimes as central and sometimes tangential to the focus of the study. An example of the latter includes studies of corporate fraud that consider gender as one of several variables contributing to fraud-enabling corporate cultures (Watson, 2003).

While it would be quite easy to justify ignoring those variable that reduce human characteristics to impartial measures arguably they provide sensemaking clues to the relationship between gender and cultural dynamics in organizational relationships. Such studies suggest that an organization’s culture can have negative effects on women’s ability or preparedness to mentor (Appelbaum et al., 1994); may have no difference on men and women’s deontological norms (Singhapakdi and Vitell, 1991); can have a difference on the construction of cultural values (Strautmanis, 2008) and perceptions of organizational culture (Bellou, 2008); and a moderating effect on perceptions of leadership and job satisfaction (Chen, 2005).

Other essentialist studies suggest that the cultural values of an organization can affect women's job satisfaction (Bellou, 2008), perceptions of their leadership abilities (Stelter, 2002) and of organizational justice (Lieberman, 2006); cultural values can also affect levels of sexual harassment (Cogin and Fish, 2009) and discriminatory stereotypes (Frohlich and Peters, 2007), but also compliance with employment equity legislation (Burgess-Wilkerson, 2008).

Strategies for addressing discrimination at work include making the culture "family friendly" (Weiler and Zimmerman, 2007); developing organizational cultures that help to overcome societal expectations of gender roles (Hossain and Kusakabe, 2005) and breaking down gender segregated work (Miller and Clark, 2008); zero tolerance of discriminatory behaviours and constant surveying of employees to monitor attitudes (Verespej, 1997).

Applying a CMS lens, we would argue that while the researchers have tended to essentialize gender and concretize organizational culture they are picked up on certain discursive associations or senses. Namely, that the use of the term organizational culture (to make sense of a series of interrelationships) – whether seen as a concrete entity or a heuristic—has come to be associated with gender inequities. Either as something that needs to be altered to address those inequities and/or as something that causes those inequities. The various studies signpost the various responses that people have when self identifying as "men" or "women" and how, when so labeled, they pick up cues from selected experiences (e.g., job satisfaction) that become enacted (through their responses and those of the researchers) as gendered realities.

Social constructivist insights

Social constructivist approaches problematize not only the relationship between organizational culture and gender but also the concepts of organizational culture and gender themselves (Coates, 1998). Organizational culture is often used as a heuristic to understand how organizational relationships contribute to gendered selves and how, in turn, gendered notions constitute so-called organizational cultures (Cartwright and Andrew, 1995). In the process they raise interesting questions about the conceptualization of "organizational change" and its impact on those involved.

Several studies focus on the processes through which gendered organizational cultures are created and maintained. These include such things as organizational rules (Mills, 1988), metaphors (Lewis and Morgan, 1994), gender dynamics (Angus, 1993), sub cultures (Gottfried and Graham, 1993), rhetoric (Gherardi, 1994), and gender imbalances (Simpson, 2000). These studies provide insights into how certain notions of masculinity and femininity are translated into privileged or marginalized practices that come to constitute a dominant set of cultural values in an organization.

Other studies focus on selected factors that may serve to reinforce those dominant gendered notions of organization, including body image (Girard, 2001), organizational commitment (Hopfl, 1992), career paths (Wilson, 1998), and presenteeism (i.e., the requirement to be ever present, ever seen in an organization—Simpson, 1998).

Within these studies strategies of change are either implied or viewed through the development of alternative ways of developing organizational relationships to those that are surfaced. In some cases, the researchers go further in developing strategies of organizational change designed to heighten awareness of the processes of gender discrimination as a method for addressing the issue. Rindfleisch et al. (2009) for example suggest the active development of stories as a sensemaking device for challenging gendered notions of organization; Kolb and Merrill-Sands (1999) argue that a strategy of surfacing gendered assumptions can be used to encourage reflexivity and challenge to taken-for-granted gendered ideas; and Dutton et al. (2002) urge

attention to the influence of context in shaping women and men's respective abilities to be willing and able to sell issues in organizations, including equity issues (Piderit and Ashford, 2003).

Summary and conclusions as further sensemaking clues

The literature on organizational change, particularly those focussed on programmatic change (e.g., TQM, BPR), has little or nothing to say about gender. This is likely rooted in the fact that most programs are narrowly focussed on managerial outcomes that are achieved through quasi-scientific methods and the assumption of gender-neutrality (or neglect). They do not preclude gender issues per se and one could imagine a scenario where some of the central techniques and foci could be applied to addressing gender discrimination—especially with an eye to even greater levels of efficiency, quality and/or commitment. Indeed, some feminists have suggested as much (Fondas, 1997; Graham and Hotchkiss, 2009).

Nonetheless, as the great bulk of studies on gender and change argues, the on-going sense of organizational change is generally enacted as a gendered sense of the organization, with far reaching consequences for the identity work of those involved.

First, a change program usually has wide-spread consequences for various aspects of the organization, including such things as layers of management, processes, the establishment of quality circles or teams, enhanced measurement techniques and goals, an array of new forms of symbolism (e.g., teams, quality circles, Black Belts), and new or elevated values (e.g., mission statements, etc). As feminist and other gender researchers have argued, changes in processes (Ferguson, 1984), structures (Kanter, 1977), and symbolism (Acker, 1992) can have serious consequences for the jobs/professions/identities of those involved. This can affect such things as mentoring (Appelbaum et al., 1994), leadership (Chen, 2005), and stereotypes (Frohlich and Peters, 2007) for better or for worst.

Second, organizations can be viewed at one level as an (on-going) sensemaking achievement whose maintenance is linked to a series of retrospective and social sensemaking activities. The notion of “team” for example can be seen as an integral part of a hospital system that privileges patient care as its central retrospective sense of organizational purpose and is supported by groups of healthcare professionals. By changing a critical part of the system (e.g., the notion of “team”) senior managers may find that this leads to important yet unanticipated changes in sensemaking cues and the overall plausibility of the project (Armstrong et al., 1997). As the literature suggests, this rarely leads to improved gender equity. Nonetheless, changes to the sensemaking environment can lead to instabilities that open up spaces for addressing gender issues. The surfacing of gender assumptions is one suggested way of destabilizing existing dominant sensemaking (Kolb and Merrill-Sands, 1999). The development of new stories (that favour gender equity) is a way of directly engaging with sensemaking processes (Rindfleisch et al., 2009). Reinterpreting as well as changing organizational rules (Mills, 1988) is yet another way of changing the sensemaking environment. As is the deliberate development of anti-discriminatory metaphors (Lewis and Morgan, 1994) to help frame changed ways of making sense in an organization.

Third, the notion of organizational change (and the various attendant elements of the concept) should be engaged with as a discursive process whose very naming may have gendered implications (Coates, 1998). At one level the very concrete connotations attached to organizational change and, through it, BPR, TQM, AI, Balanced Scorecard, Organizational Culture, may serve to naturalize the sense made of such activities and practices and with it those associated with gender disparities (Lewis and Morgan, 1994; Stelter, 2002). The same can be said of the socially constructed character of such things as careers (Wilson, 1998), organizational commitment

(Hopfl, 1992), and body image (Girard, 2001). Exploration of these aspect of organizational life reveal them to be well established myths of on-going sensemaking whose gendered effects are often exacerbated by association with other powerful sensemaking myths such as the culture of an organization. Thus, challenges need to be mounted not only at the overall and on-going sense of an organization in, for example, the form of an organization's culture but also in many of its constituent and interrelated parts, such as career paths.

Ultimately, organizational change presents challenges to feminists in two main ways. First, there is the need to engage with and make sense of organizational change from a feminist perspective, to develop a new sense of organizational change that will centrally embrace the need to develop reflexive, anti-sexist, equitable organizational processes (the Abella Commission provided a valuable template for such a project—Abella, 1984). This requires a far reaching synthesis of the various insights from the feminist literature on work and organization. Second, and not divorced from the first project, there is a need for feminist engagement with the dominant discourse of organizational change to develop further insights into the challenges and potentialities of change and resistance. We hope that, at least in a small way, we have made a contribution to the latter project.

References

- Abella, R.S. 1984. *Equity in Employment: A Royal Commission Report*. Ottawa: Ministry of Supply and Services Canada.
- Abrahamson, E. 1996. Management fashion. *Academy of Management Review*, 21(1): 254–85.
- Acker, J. 1992. Gendering organizational theory. In A.J. Mills, and P. Tancred (eds.), *Gendering Organizational Analysis*: 248–60. Newbury Park, CA: SAGE.
- Aksu, M.B. 2003. TQM readiness level perceived by the administrators working for the central organization of the Ministry of National Education in Turkey. *Total Quality Management*, 14(5): 591–604.
- Altman, R.E., II. 2006. *A survey of perceived managerial competencies of cardiac rehabilitation professionals in a hospital setting*. Unpublished D.Ed., Indiana University of Pennsylvania.
- Angus, L.B. 1993. Masculinity and women teachers at Christian Brothers College. *Organization Studies*, 14(2): 235–61.
- Appelbaum, S. H., Ritchie, S., and Sharpiro, B. T. 1994. Mentoring revisited: An organizational behaviour construct. *Journal of Management Development*, 13(4): 62–72.
- Armstrong, P., Armstrong, H., Choiniere, J., Mykhalovskiy, E., and White, J. 1997. *Medical Alert: New Work Organizations in Health Care*. Toronto: Garamond Press.
- Bellou, V. 2008. Identifying organizational culture and subcultures within Greek public hospitals. *Journal of Health Organization and Management*, 22(5): 496–509.
- Braverman, H. 1974. *Labor and Monopoly Capital*. New York: Monthly Review Press.
- Burgess-Wilkerson, B. 2008. Selection and interview procedures at a multinational company. *Business Communication Quarterly*, 71(1): 100–102.
- Burrell, G. and Morgan, G. 1979. *Sociological Paradigms and Organizational Analysis*. London: Heinemann.
- Cartwright, S. and Andrew, G. 1995. Project management: Different gender, different culture? A discussion on gender and organizational culture—Part 2. *Leadership and Organization Development Journal*, 16(4): 12–16.
- Chen, L.-T. 2005. Exploring the relationship among transformational and transactional leadership behavior, job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and turnover on the IT Department of Research and Development in Shanghai, China. Nova Southeastern University, Florida.
- Coates, G. 1998. Integration or separation: women and the application of organisational culture. *Women in Management Review*, 13(3): 114–.
- Coch, L. and French, J.R.P. 1948. Overcoming Resistance To Change. *Human Relations*, 1: 512–32.
- Cockerill-Walker, J.L. 1997. An exploratory study of quality improvement team participants' experience. Unpublished Ed. D, University of Nebraska – Lincoln.

- Cogin, J. and Fish, A. 2009. Sexual harassment—a touchy subject for nurses. *Journal of Health Organization and Management*, 23(4): 442–62.
- Collinson, D.L., and Hearn, J. 1994. Naming men as men: implications for work, organization and management. *Gender, Work and Organization*, 1(1): 2–22.
- Davies, S. 1984. *Managing Corporate Culture*. Cambridge, MA: Ballinger.
- Deal, T.E. and Kennedy, A.A. 1982. *Corporate Cultures*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Dowlatshahi, S. 1994. Reengineering in higher education: A case study. *Human Systems Management*, 13(4): 303–7.
- Dutton, J.E., Ashford, S.J., Lawrence, K.A., and Miner-Rubino, K. 2002. Red light, green light: Making sense of the organizational context for selling issued. *Organization Science*, 13(4): 355–71.
- Ehigie, B.O. and Akpan, R.C. 2005. Psycho-social factors influencing practice of total quality management in some Nigerian organizations. *Journal of Managerial Psychology*, 20(5/6): 355–79.
- Ehigie, B.O. and McAndrew, E.B. 2005. Innovation, diffusion and adoption of total quality management (TQM). *Management Decision*, 43(5/6): 925–40.
- Ferguson, K. 1984. *The Feminist Case against Bureaucracy*. Philadelphia, PA: Temple University Press.
- Floeter-van Wijk, S.W. 2007. *The Gender Balanced Scorecard: A Management Tool to Achieve Gender Mainstreaming in Organisational Culture*. Frankfurt am Main; New York: Lang.
- Fondas, N. 1997. Feminization unveiled: management qualities in contemporary writings. *Academy of Management Review*, 22(1): 257–82.
- Foucault, M. 1979. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. New York: Vintage Books.
- Foucault, M. 1980. *Power/Knowledge*. New York: Pantheon.
- French, W.L. and Bell, C. 1972. *Organization Development: Behavioral Science Interventions for Organization Improvement*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.
- Frohlich, R. and Peters, S.B. 2007. PR bunnies caught in the agency ghetto? Gender stereotypes, organizational factors and women's careers in PR agencies. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 19(3): 229–54.
- Gherardi, S. 1994. The gender we think, the gender we do in our everyday organizational lives. *Human Relations*, 47(6): 591–611.
- Gherardi, S. 1995. *Gender, Symbolism and Organizational Cultures*. London: SAGE.
- Girard, A.E. 2001. The female executive: Experiences of body and self in the corporate culture. Unpublished Psy.D., Widener University, Pennsylvania.
- Gottfried, H. and Graham, L. 1993. Constructing difference: The making of gendered subcultures. *Sociology*, 2(4): 611–29.
- Graham, M.E. and Hotchkiss, J.L. 2009. A more proactive approach to addressing gender-related employment disparities in the United States. *Gender in Management*, 24(8): 577.
- Hackman, J.R. and Oldham, G. 1980. *Work Redesign*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Hammer, M. 1990. Reengineering work: Don't automate, obliterate. *Harvard Business Review*, 68(4): 104–12.
- Hammer, M. 1995. *The Re-engineering Revolution*. New York: Harper & Collins.
- Hammer, M. and Champy, J. 1993. *Reengineering the Corporation*. New York: HarperCollins.
- Hearn, J., and Parkin, P.W. 1983. Gender and organizations: A selective review and a critique of a neglected area. *Organization Studies*, 4(3): 219–42.
- Helms Mills, J. 2003. *Making Sense of Organizational Change*. London: Routledge.
- Helms Mills, J. 2005. Representations of Diversity and Organizational Change in a North American Utility Company. *Gender, Work and Organization*, 12(3): 242–69.
- Helms Mills, J. 2010. Sensemaking. In A.J. Mills, Durepos, G., and Wiebe, E. (eds), *The SAGE Encyclopedia of Case Studies*, Vol. II: 852–55. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications.
- Helms Mills, J. and Mills, A.J. 2009. Critical sensemaking and workplace inequities. In M. Ozbilgin (ed.), *Equality, Diversity and Inclusion at Work: Theory and Scholarship*: 171–78. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar.
- Helms Mills, J., Dye, K.E., and Mills, A.J. 2008. *Understanding organizational change*. Abingdon, Oxon: Routledge.
- Ho, Danny C.K., Duffy, V.G.D., and Shih, Heloisa M. 1999. An empirical analysis of effective TQM implementation in the Hong Kong electronics manufacturing industry. *Human Factors and Ergonomics in Manufacturing*, 9(1): 1–25.

- Hopfl, H. 1992. Commitments and conflicts: corporate seduction and ambivalence in women managers. *Women in Management Review*, 7(1): 9–17.
- Hossain, J.B. and Kusakabe, K. 2005. Sex segregation in construction organizations in Bangladesh and Thailand. *Construction Management and Economics*, 23(1): 609–19.
- Jackson, B. 2001. *Management Gurus and Management Fashions*. London: Routledge.
- Johnson, P. and Duberley, J. 2000. *Understanding Management Research* London: SAGE.
- Kanter, R.M. 1977. *Men and Women of the Corporation*. New York: Basic Books.
- Kaplan, R.S. and Norton, D.P. 1992. The Balanced Scorecard: measures that drive performance. *Harvard Business Review* (January–February): 71–79.
- Kieser, A. 1997. Rhetoric and myth in management fashion. *Organization*, 4(1): 49–74.
- Kolb, D.M. and Merrill-Sands, D. 1999. Waiting for outcomes: anchoring a dual agenda for change to cultural assumptions. *Women in Management Review*, 14(5): 194–.
- Kotter, J.P. 1996. *Leading change*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press.
- Lewis, J. and Morgan, D.H.J. 1994. Gendering organizational change: The case of relate, 1948–90. *Human Relations*, 47(6): 641.
- Lian, T.K.F. 2001. Determinants of Total Quality Management (TQM) implementation and impact: A study of selected Malaysian public organizations. Unpublished D.P.A., University of Georgia.
- Lieberman, E. 2006. What's fair is fair, or is it? The effects of merit-related managerial behaviors and organizational policies on organizational justice perceptions. City University of New York, New York.
- Miller, K. and Clark, D. 2008. "Knife before wife": an exploratory study of gender in the UK medical profession. *Journal of Health Organization and Management*, 22(3): 238–53.
- Mills, A.J. 1988. Organization, gender and culture. *Organization Studies*, 9(3): 351–69.
- Mills, A.J. 2008a. Getting Critical About Sensemaking. In D. Barry, and H. Hansen (eds), *The SAGE Handbook of New Approaches to Organization Studies*: 29–30. London: SAGE.
- Mills, A.J. 2008b. Organizational rules. In S.R. Clegg, and J. Barley (eds), *Encyclopedia of Organisation Studies* London: SAGE.
- Mills, A.J. and Helms Mills, J. 2004. When plausibility fails: towards a critical sensemaking approach to resistance. In R. Thomas, A.J. Mills, and J. Helms Mills (eds), *Identity Politics at Work: Resisting Gender and Gendered Resistance*: 141–59. London: Routledge.
- Mills, A.J. and Helms Mills, J. 2010. Making sense of gender: self reflections on the creation of plausible accounts. In S. Katila, S. Meriläinen, and J. Tienari (eds), *Working for Inclusion: Positive Experiences from Academics Across the World*: 244–73. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar.
- Mintzberg, H. 1978. Patterns in strategy formulation. *Management Science*, 14: 934–948.
- Morreale, S.A. 2002. Analysis of perceived leader behaviours in law enforcement agencies. Unpublished D.P.A., Nova Southeastern University.
- Peters, T. and Waterman, R. 1982. *In Search of Excellence—Lessons from America's Best Run Companies*. New York: Warner Communications.
- Piderit, S.K. and Ashford, S.J. 2003. Breaking silence: Tactical choices women managers make in speaking up about gender-equity issues. *Journal of Management Studies*, 40(6): 1477–1502.
- Porter, M.E. 1980. *Competitive Strategy*. New York: Free Press.
- Prasad, P. 2005. *Crafting Qualitative Research. Working in the Postpositivist Traditions*. Armonk, NY: M. E. Sharpe.
- Rindfleish, J., Sheridan, A., and Kjeldal, S.-E. 2009. Creating an "agora" for storytelling as a way of challenging the gendered structures of academia. *Equal Opportunities International*, 28(6): 486–99.
- Ryan, M. 1979. *Womanhood in America*. New York: Viewpoints.
- Schein, E.H. 1985. *Organizational Culture and Leadership*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.
- Schein, E.H. 1992. *Organizational Culture and Leadership* (2nd ed.). San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.
- Sekerka, L.E., Brumbaugh, A.M., Rosa, J.A., and Cooperrider, D. 2006. Comparing Appreciative Inquiry to a diagnostic technique in organizational change: the moderating effects of gender. *International Journal of Organization Theory and Behavior*, 9(4): 449–89.
- Simpson, R. 1998. Organizational restructuring and presenteeism: The impact of long hours on the working lives of managers in the UK. *Management Research News*, 21(2/3): 19–20.

- Simpson, R. 2000. Gender mix and organizational fit: how gender imbalance at different levels of the organisation impacts on women managers. *Women in Management Review*, 15(1): 5-.
- Singhapakdi, A. and Vitell, S.J., Jr. 1991. Research note: selected factors influencing marketers' deontological norms. *Academy of Marketing Science*, 19(1): 37-42.
- Smircich, L. 1983. Concepts of culture and organizational analysis. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, (28): 339-58.
- Stelter, N.Z. 2002. Gender differences in leadership: Current social issues and future organizational implications. *Journal of Leadership and Organizational Studies*, 8(4): 88-99.
- Strautmanis, J. 2008. Employees' values orientation in the context of corporate social responsibility. *Baltic Journal of Management*, 3(3): 346-58.
- Thurlow, A. 2010. Critical Sensemaking. In A.J. Mills, G. Durepos, and E. Weibe (eds.), *SAGE Encyclopedia of Case Study Research*, vol. I: 257-60. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE.
- Unger, R.M. 1987. *Social Theory: Its Situation and Its Task*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Urwick, L. and Brech, E.F.L. 1944. *The Human Factor in Management 1795-1943*. London: Institute of Labour Management.
- Verespej, M.A. 1997. Zero tolerance, *Industry Week*, vol. 246: 24-27.
- Watson, D.M. 2003. Cultural dynamics of corporate fraud. *Cross Cultural Management*, 10(1): 40-54.
- Weick, K.E. 1979. *The Social Psychology of Organizing* (2nd ed.). Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Weick, K.E. 1985. The significance of corporate culture. In P. Frost, L. Moore, M. Louis, C. Lundberg, and J. Martin (eds.), *Organizational Culture*: 381-89. London: SAGE.
- Weick, K.E. 1995. *Sensemaking in Organizations*. London: SAGE.
- Weick, K.E. 2001. *Making Sense of the Organization*. Oxford: Blackwell.
- Weiler, P.A. and Zimmerman, M. 2007. Narrowing the gender gap in healthcare management. *Healthcare Executive*, 22(3): 0-28.
- Wilson, E.M. 1998. Gendered career paths. *Personnel Review*, 27(5): 396.
- Wilson, F.M. 2003. *Organizational Behaviour and Gender* (2nd ed.). Aldershot: Ashgate.